

"The Church of Ephesus"

Text: Revelation 2:1 - 7

Introduction: If you had been living at the time of the writing about the seven churches of Revelation and you wanted to live in the most exciting city in the world, you probably would have selected Ephesus. Two hundred thirty cities dotted the coastline of Asia Minor, and many of them were great cities, but Ephesus was the queen of them all.

Ephesus was not only known for its commercial trade, but for the great Temple of Diana, which was one of the Seven Wonders of the World. Diana was the goddess with the *grotesque* head and many breasts which focused her worshiper's attention on the sensual pleasure of prostitution.

Paul went to Ephesus on his third missionary journey. He stayed there two years. He wrote of the latter in **I Corinthians 16:9**, saying, "For a great door and effectual is opened unto me, and there are many adversaries."

The church of Ephesus is the first church we read about in the book of Revelation. The seven churches are: Ephesus, Smyrna, Pergamos, Thyatira, Sardis, Philadelphia, and Laodicea. There were other churches in Asia. They were: Troas (**Acts 20:5; II Corinthians 2:12**), Miletus (**Acts 20:17**), Colossi (**Col. 1:2**), and Hierapolis (**Col. 4:12**). The Bible does not tell us why John did not write to them, but we can assume two things:

- (1) **THE CHOICE.** God chose the seven churches that were symbolic of seven kinds of churches that were to exist in the future. One thing that caused Him to choose the ones He did was:
- (2) **THEIR CHARACTERISTICS.** Even though each of the seven churches had similarities, each one was different. This is, and always has been, true.

Illus: As you travel across America today you will find that all churches have similarities, yet, still, there are major differences also.

Only as we do a sincere, honest, inventory of ourselves can we find which church we are and where we stand with the Lord Jesus Christ. Let us look

at the seven verses of scripture that deal with the church at Ephesus to see how we, as a church, compare to that church. The first thing the Word of God reveals to us about the people in the church at Ephesus deals with.....

I. THEIR LEADER

In verse 1 we read, "Unto the angel of the church of Ephesus write; These things saith he that holdeth the seven stars in his right hand, who walketh in the midst of the seven golden candlesticks;....." This letter is addressed to the leader of the church. We read, "Unto the **ANGEL** of the church of Ephesus...." Notice, the word "**angel**" is singular, not plural. He is not addressing ALL seven church leaders; He is addressing the one leader of the church of Ephesus.

This letter is written to "....the **ANGEL OF THE CHURCH OF EPHESUS**...." who is the **PASTOR**. He is the messenger of God to the church.

Illus: Sometimes people will ask, "How does a preacher know what to preach?" Simple. God tells him what to Preach. God speaks **TO HIM** and **THROUGH HIM**. He is God's messenger.

God does not tell the deacons and have them tell the pastor what He wants. God holds the pastor personally responsible. God is a God of organization, not a God of confusion. The pastor must never forget that God has placed him over the flock and with that special responsibility comes special accountability for the task assigned. Look at **I Peter 5:2**, where we read, "Feed the flock of God which is among you, taking the oversight thereof, not by constraint, but willingly; not for filthy lucre, but of a ready mind." The pastor is to "....FEED THE FLOCK...." and he is to "TAKE THE OVERSIGHT THEREOF."

Notice some things that verse one tells us about the minister God. He is referred to as an ANGEL. Then notice, John switches to the plural - "STARS." That is, God holds ALL of His ministers in His hands.

The minister of God is.....

- Held in the hands of Christ. ".....These things saith he that holdeth the seven stars in his right hand...."
- Hand-picked by Christ and placed in His hand.
- Nourished and nurtured by the hand of Christ.
- Protected by the hand of Christ.
- Positioned for a close relationship, being in the hand of Christ. Why? Because of his position in the church. It is a very rare position!

This letter was written to **THE LEADER** of the church of Ephesus.

- A family has to have a **LEADER**.
- A nation has to have a **LEADER**.
- A business has to have a **LEADER**.
- A team has to have a **LEADER**, and,
- **A CHURCH HAS TO HAVE A LEADER.** When God was ready to address the church at Ephesus, He recognized the pastor as the leader of His church - it was to the pastor this letter was written.

II. THE LAMPSTAND.

Look at verse 1, where we read, ".....who walketh in the midst of the seven golden candlesticks...." The seven golden candlesticks represent the seven churches of Revelation.

As a pastor, I cannot express how honored I feel to have you as a part of this church. I recognize there are good churches all over this city that you could attend, but you are here because God has led us together to build a lighthouse for Him in this community. As much as words can convey, I deeply appreciate every one of you! But, not one of us would be here if the Lord Jesus was not here.

Sometimes we hear people say, "I do not like to go to church." Generally they are not trying to be ugly when they say that; they sincerely mean it. They are not to be blamed. There are some "churches" Christians are not comfortable in. Why? If God is not there, they do not want to be there either.

What is a church? Simply defined, it is: "A place where Christ has promised to meet those who have come together because they love Him."

Look at verse 1 again, ".....who walketh in the **MIDST** of the seven golden candlesticks." Look at that word "midst." It is the same word we see in the promise in **Matthew 18:20**, "For where two or three are gathered together in my name, there am I in the **MIDST** of them." The pride and joy of a Bible-believing church is that the PRESENCE OF THE LORD is among them.

Illus: The streets of gold are not what will make heaven a great place. What is going to make heaven so great is the Lord Jesus. He is going to be the center attraction! The thing that makes a church a great place is not the building the people worship in, but that the Lord is there! There would be no reason to assemble if He were not there.

If a church has lost the presence of the Lord, it has lost everything. The people may as well shut the door and write ICABOD across the door lintel. We had better never take the presence of the Lord for granted!

Illus: Did you know that what makes Hell so terrible is not the eternal flames, nor the evil people who will inhabit that place? The thing that makes hell so terrible is the fact that GOD IS NOT THERE!

John tells us about THE LEADER, and THE LAMPSTAND of the church of Ephesus. He also tells us about.....

III. THEIR LABOR.

In verses 2-3 we read, "I **KNOW** thy works, and thy labour, and thy patience, and how thou canst not bear them which are evil: and thou hast tried them which say they are apostles, and are not, and hast found them liars: And hast borne, and hast patience, and for my name's sake has laboured, and hast not fainted." Look at the word "know" in verse 2; it means absolutely He has clear vision of knowing what is going on in the church today.

You see, there is not anything to obstruct **HIS** view of the church. He not only sees **WHO PHYSICALLY ATTENDS HIS CHURCH**, He also is able to look into the hearts of those who attend and **KNOWS WHY THEY ATTEND HIS CHURCH**.

The church of Ephesus was a busy church. The church calendar was filled with many things.

Illus: They were not like the church that sent their annual report into headquarters which stated, "No baptisms, no new members by letter, not deaths, no births, no gifts to missions." Then, at the bottom of the report, a note was added which said, "Brethren, pray for us that we will hold our own."

That was not the case with the church of Ephesus. Their people could write a wonderful report telling headquarters what they were doing. Look as we read what the Lord said about them.....

- A. **"I know thy works, and thy labour..."** We need to understand here the Lord is commending believers for their works. He does not ask lost people to work for Him. Why? Because if He did they would think they were earning their salvation by those good works. However, we who are saved by His marvelous grace are expected to work. If we are not willing to work then God's work will not be done.

The church of Ephesus was not like many churches today. Often it is hard to find Christians willing to work for the Lord, but the Word of God tells us the Christians of Ephesus were willing and they laboured for the Lord.

- B. **"I knowthy patience..."** In that pagan land, where the goddess Diana was supreme, the Christians encountered many problems, but God commended them because they were patient and did not throw up their hands and quit.
- C. **"I know...how thou canst not bear them which are evil..."** Look at the phrase, "....canst not bear." The Ephesian Christians would not tolerate for a moment a church leader who did not live a holy life. How different it is today in many cases. We have churches across America that allow **ungodly men and women**, to continue in their fellowship, even though they know they are living ungodly, unholy lives and no one says a word against it. The church of Ephesus would not tolerate evil among them.

- D. "I know...thou hast tried them which say they are apostles, and are not, and has found them liars." Look at the words "tried them." They did not swallow everything that was spewed out. They literally checked people out with the Word of God and if they did not line up with God's Word they dismissed them with their teachings. You might wonder if that was scriptural. Yes, it was - and is! **I John 4:1** says, "Beloved, believe not every spirit, BUT TRY THE SPIRITS whether they are of God....." God has warned us that "wolves" would come to us in "sheep's" clothing, yet many today will swallow anything that is passed down to them as the gospel.
- E. "I know...how thou...hast borne, and has patience, and for my name's sake hast labored, and hast not fainted." The church of Ephesus suffered many difficulties, but they stood for the name of Christ. Notice, under that stressful load that they did not faint. The Word of God, **II Thessalonians 3:13**, tells us, "...be not weary in well doing."

Illus: D.L. Moody came home from holding a gospel campaign completely exhausted. His family begged him to stay home and rest before he went on to his next meeting. He told them "I grow weary in the work but not of the work."

You see, everyone who has ever faithfully served the Lord knows what he means. Sometimes our bodies are exhausted because of the load we are carrying, but we never think of giving up because of the load. That is, we may grow weary in the work of God, but God helps us to never grow weary of His work.

IV. THEIR LEAVING.

The church at Ephesus never grew weary of the work of the Lord! So far, everything we read about this church seems to describe what seems to be a good church. In fact, I do not know many pastors who would not be honored to pastor such a church. But remember, God, Who said that He knew their WORKS, LABOUR, PATIENCE, ETC., is the God Who can look into the hearts of men and see what others cannot see! There was "a fly in their soup." He looked into their hearts, after saying all those nice things about them, and exposed a major fault - verse 4, "Nevertheless I have somewhat against thee, because thou hast left thy first love."

Our love for the Lord is what makes His church an exciting place to be. It is possible to serve God every day of the week because it is routine instead of serving Him out of love for Him.

Illus: Did you know that a woman can work at a plant and quit working there to get married and if you ask her if she still works she will say, "No I do not work anymore. I got married." Does she mean she no longer does any work? Of course not. She gets up early and cooks breakfast for that man she adores. She scrubs and cleans house, washes clothes, irons, and puts the clothes away, takes care of the other chores, and when it is almost time for him to come home, she cooks a nutritious meal and anxiously waits for him to drive up. Yet she says that she doesn't work! What she means is that because she loves him, all those things she does do not seem like work.

V. THE LESSON.

The lesson to be learned from the church of Ephesus is that we can go through all the ritualism of worship and service and still NOT LOVE THE LORD JESUS. Instead of church being a place where Christians meet because they love the Lord, it can become just a routine thing to do.

Illus: It is possible to place God's tithes and our offerings in an offering plate and never have God on our minds. We can sing beautiful hymns and never think about the words we are singing. We can hear wonderful sermons from the Word of God and never allow them to penetrate our hearts.

Jesus said to the church of Ephesus, and other churches that are like them, "Remember therefore from whence thou art fallen, and repent and do the first works; or else I will come unto thee quickly, and I will remove thy candlestick out of his place, except thou repent."

Conclusion/Summary:

- I. THEIR LEADER.
- II. THE LAMPSTAND.
- III. THEIR LABOR.
- IV. THEIR LEAVING.
- V. THE LESSON.